

Banner vs Slate -- Which Is Easier?

GWC Automated Eligibility Pipeline -- Data Source Comparison

RECOMMENDATION: Use Banner as the data source. Use Slate only for notifications.

Banner has live, current data. Slate has application-time snapshots that go stale.

Field	Slate	Banner
What it holds	Applications, comms, recruitment	Live current student record
Data freshness	Snapshot from application date	Updates on every registration/drop/aid change
GPA	Does NOT have it	Has it (updated after every term)
Units in progress	Does NOT have it	Has it (updates on add/drop)
Financial aid (BOG, Pell)	Does NOT have it	Has it (live from FA module)
Residency	Has it (from CCCApply)	Has it (can update if reclassified)
Foster youth / Homeless	Has it (from CCCApply)	Has it (copied from intake)
Income bracket / SAI	Does NOT have it	Has it (from FAFSA/ISIR processing)
Marital status	Has it (from CCCApply)	Has it (copied from intake)
API access	Slate REST API (query-based)	Ethos Integration API (REST)
Who controls access	Enrollment/Marketing team	Central IT
Ease of getting access	Medium (Slate admin can grant)	Harder (IT security review)

Key Insight

Slate has the application. Banner has the truth. The eligibility check needs LIVE data -- current GPA, current units, current aid status. Banner is the only system that stays current. Slate would give you stale data from 6 months ago.

Recommended Architecture

Banner (data source)	--->	Our Eligibility Engine	--->	Slate (delivery layer)
Live student data		Rules-based check		Sends emails/portal
Updated in real-time		Deterministic result		notifications to student

Student logs in --> System reads Banner --> Engine runs --> Banner shows / Slate emails

How New Students Get Screened

Trigger 1: Every Login (real-time)

- * Student logs into portal
- * System pulls current Banner data (cached 24 hours)
- * Eligibility engine runs against live data
- * If qualified: banner appears. If not: nothing shown, recheck next login.
- * Catches students the moment their data is complete in Banner.

Trigger 2: Nightly Batch (catch everyone)

- * Every night at 2 AM: query Banner for ALL active students
- * Run eligibility engine on each record
- * Store results in a cache table (instant lookup on next login)
- * Optionally: Slate sends proactive email to newly-eligible students
- * No student falls through the cracks even if they never log in.

Does It Keep Asking Until They Say Yes?

Accept Student is enrolled/waitlisted. Banner never shows again for that program. Record saved.

Opt-out (session) Dismissed for current session. Reappears next login. Students may change their mind.

Opt-out (permanent) Dismissed forever. Record saved. Banner never shows again unless student asks.

Fixed Dataset or Live?

LIVE. It re-checks every login because student situations change:

Student registers for more units	--> May now meet 12-unit requirement
FAFSA gets processed	--> BOG waiver, Pell, SAI now available
Student drops below 12 units	--> May lose EOPS eligibility
Residency reclassified	--> Non-resident becomes Resident
Student becomes a parent	--> May now qualify for CARE
Student receives CalWORKs	--> Now qualifies for CalWORKs program

Bottom line: Banner feeds the data. Our engine makes the decision. Slate delivers the message.

A fixed Slate export would be wrong within weeks. Banner stays current because everyone writes to it.